PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota Land Cruiser 70 Series

1984–present · J70 · 76 · 78 · 79

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Check the A-pillars for rust**
  Unsealed 4X4 says rust usually starts from the inside, so look for bubbling and flaking paint and run a magnet over suspect areas. Coastal trucks rot in the A-pillars and let water in. The magazine knows of one owner who paid nearly A$15,000 to replace both pillars, so its advice is to walk away.
- [ ] **Look at the rear spring hangers**
  Trucks that regularly ran over GVM on rough roads can crack at the weld where the rear spring hanger meets the frame. Look for cracks, fresh welds or reinforcement plates, and listen for a clunk under load.
- [ ] **Open the airbox**
  On the V8, a weak airbox seal lets dust past the filter. Unclip the lid and check the clean side of the filter: if there's dust there, Unsealed says the engine is on borrowed time.
- [ ] **Shift through every gear**
  Crunching between second and third points to worn synchros. Unsealed 4X4 blames GL-5 oil, whose extreme-pressure additives attack the yellow-metal synchro rings, and says to use GL-4 75W-90. Other spec sheets list GL-4 or GL-5, so check what your manual calls for.
- [ ] **Test the clutch on tuned trucks**
  The stock clutch is built for stock power. If the revs rise without the truck accelerating, or it bites at the very top of the pedal, budget for a heavy-duty clutch.
- [ ] **Jack up the front wheels**
  Grab each front tire at 12 and 6 o'clock and rock it. Play or a hum that rises to a howl with speed points to front wheel bearings, which work hard on heavy, big-tired 70s.
- [ ] **Ask about the DPF (late-2016-on V8s)**
  Look for DPF warning lights, smoke or a history of limp mode, especially on trucks that mostly did short trips.
- [ ] **Importing? Check the build date**
  For a US import, NHTSA's exemption is based on age: the truck must be more than 25 years old. Check the build plate before you pay, and remember that a lot of imports have spent their lives working on farms or mine sites.

YEARS TO KNOW

2007	SWEET SPOT	Big facelift for the 4.5 L 1VD-FTV turbo-diesel V8: wider front track and chassis, flat front fenders gone, 76 four-door wagon and GXL grade added. Unsealed 4X4 says many enthusiasts favour the 2007–16 V8s, which are simpler because they have no DPF

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Model code = engine + wheelbase**
  The prefix letters name the engine: FJ = 3F petrol, FZJ = 1FZ petrol, BJ = 3B diesel, HJ = 2H, HZJ = 1HZ, PZJ = 1PZ, LJ = 2L family, KZJ = 1KZ, VDJ = 1VD-FTV V8, GRJ = 1GR V6, GDJ = 1GD. The numbers give the body: 70/71 short wheelbase, 73/74 medium, 75/78/79 long (pickup and Troop Carrier), 76/77 four-door semi-long wagons.
- [ ] **Pre- or post-1999**
  From the August 1999 facelift, trucks have a coil-sprung front axle and 5-stud wheels. Earlier trucks have leaf springs at the front and 6-stud wheels. The three-bar grille with upturned ends also dates from that facelift.
- [ ] **Not every '70' is a heavy-duty 70**
  From 1985 to 1996, Toyota also sold lighter-duty models under the 70 designation, called Bundera, Land Cruiser II and later Prado. They grew into the separate 90-series Prado, so don't pay heavy-duty money for one.
- [ ] **V8 front clip**
  2007-on V8 trucks lose the flat front fenders and get a wider front track and chassis. If a 'VDJ' still has the old flat-fender nose, look harder.
- [ ] **Lockers**
  Selectable front and rear diff locks were factory options in some markets, not standard everywhere. Confirm working factory lockers rather than trusting the ad.

NOTES

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